

Stage 5 — Growth Engine & Monetization

Timing: Month 9–12 | Objective: Scale acquisition only after retention and economics are understood

Primary task

Build repeatable customer and vendor acquisition channels while protecting unit economics.

Growth channels

- Develop a consistent content engine across relevant social channels.
- Test customer referrals and vendor-led acquisition.
- Experiment with paid acquisition only when CAC, AOV, contribution margin and repeat behavior are measurable.
- Create channel-specific attribution so growth spend can be evaluated.

Vendor growth

- Develop a repeatable vendor acquisition funnel.
- Create onboarding materials and vendor education.
- Track vendor activation: listed products → first order → repeat order activity.
- Identify and retain high-performing vendors.

Monetization

- Evaluate the existing marketplace take rate and escrow fee using real transaction data.
- Consider vendor SaaS only where vendors demonstrate willingness to pay for valuable tools.
- Evaluate promoted listings, analytics or other services only if they improve marketplace economics without degrading customer experience.

Growth controls

- Set acquisition budgets based on measurable economics.
- Do not optimize campaigns for installs alone.
- Monitor fraud, refunds, support load and delivery quality while acquisition increases.

Lean Startup application

- Run growth experiments with explicit hypotheses, measurable outcomes and stopping criteria.
- Use cohort and channel data to distinguish sustainable growth from one-time promotional spikes.
- Scale experiments that improve validated metrics and stop experiments that repeatedly fail.

Exit criteria

- At least one acquisition channel shows repeatable performance.
- Vendor acquisition is becoming systematic.
- Unit economics are sufficiently understood to guide growth spending.
- Operational quality remains acceptable as volume rises.

Founder question: If we doubled acquisition spend next month, which metric would tell us whether we are creating durable customers rather than buying temporary volume?

Framework reference: Eric Ries, *The Lean Startup* (Crown Business, 2011). This roadmap applies Lean Startup concepts such as validated learning, the Build–Measure–Learn loop, minimum viable product (MVP), innovation accounting, and pivot/persevere decisions. It does not reproduce the book's text.